reimagined as something different than the mere blending of divergent communities into a singular whole.

The best path to make India hospitable for all religious groups would therefore require 'Indian leaders of political thought [to] get rid of the idea of a unitary Indian nation based on something like a biological fusion of the communities'.[9] Iqbal further corrected Nehru that it was not democracy that Indian Muslims feared, as the latter had insinuated in an earlier speech. What Muslims feared was 'communal [Hindu] oligarchy in the garb of democracy'.[10] Iqbal grimly predicted that if Nehru continued to prop up nationalism as the catch-all solution for India's communal and constitutional woes, 'the country will have to be redistributed on the basis of religious, historical and cultural affinities'.[11]

Iqbal would have also accepted Nehru's socialist brotherhood only on the condition of divorcing classical Marxist theory from atheism and making the entire redistributive justice argument more amiable to religion.[12] Only 'Bolshevism plus God', Iqbal wrote to a British admirer, would come close to the Islamic notions of justice he cherished.[13] Perhaps consequentially, this 'plus God' part brought Iqbal into a heated exchange with Nehru in 1935.

IQBAL FIRST ENTERED the national limelight in 1905. During a lecture for the Young Men's Indian Association, a student group loosely modelled on the Young Men's Christian Association (YMCA), Iqbal had skipped his formal speech and decided to sing a hymn he had recently written instead. A few years later, those words would be chanted loudly at anti-colonial rallies all over British India: '*Saare jahaan se acche, yeh Hindustan hamaara* […] *Hindi hain ham, watan hai Hindustan hamara* [Better than the entire world, is our Hindustan (…) We are of Hind, our homeland is Hindustan].'[14] More than any of his rather abstract philosophical writings or his politically charged poetry, it was this hymn that turned Iqbal into a known entity on India's cultural scene.